

Clean house: On India's septic tank desludging

Septic tank desludging must be **mechanised** completely

Behind the **hazardous** cleaning deaths of 150 people in 2022 and 2023, a **social audit** of 54 of which the Ministry of Social Justice has **tabled** in Parliament, **lies** a **deleterious** business model. Local contractors had hired 38; only five were on a government **payroll**. The rest were public sector workers 'loaned' to private employers, **obscuring liability**. **Progress** on this **front** **has lagged** despite the **Prohibition** of Employment as Manual **Scavengers** and their **Rehabilitation** Act 2013, court orders, Swachh Bharat advisories, and the 2023 National Action for Mechanised Sanitation Ecosystem (NAMASTE) scheme. A 2024 Parliament reply said 57,758 workers were engaged in hazardous cleaning **nationwide** but only 16,791 PPE kits were supplied. Fewer than 14,000 had received health cards and only 837 safety workshops had been conducted in 4,800 urban local bodies. There are at least two **bright spots**, however. In Odisha, identified workers have PPE kits and access to mechanised desludging vehicles and Tamil Nadu has **piloted** sewer robots in Chennai to clean over 5,000 manholes. Technology and political **will** can thus deliver the desired results but little has reached most districts. Experts also **flagged** a near-complete lack of data on rural sanitation workers.

India's real problem is **enforcement**. Industry members have said most underground **infrastructure** can be cleaned **robotically** if **capital subsidies** and operator training expand, yet government tenders often **solicit** manual **bids**. Most emergency response sanitation units are **paper tigers**. Only ₹14 crore has been released so far under the NAMASTE scheme, insufficient to mechanise sewer cleaning in even one major city. **In the event of** a worker death, police routinely **book** the lowest ranking supervisor or **classify** the death as an accident. The Supreme Court has asked for **offending** contracts to be cancelled and **monetary** liabilities **imposed** on **principal employers**, but local bodies are still to notify such rules. **Two-thirds** of validated workers **are** also Dalits, yet **rehabilitation** packages rarely include housing or scholarships that might help families exit **contemptible occupations**. **Women** who still **sweep** dry latrines **receive** even less policy attention. Among other measures, urban local bodies must mechanise sewer-cleaning **post haste**, and make it a licensed trade, and operating without a **valid** certificate a **cognisable** offence. **Loans** for workers to operate the machines that replace manual entry **should** be **upscaled** and linked to guaranteed service contracts from municipalities. Finally, the national government should include septic tank desludging under the Swachh Bharat rural budget and extend NAMASTE **profiling** to gram panchayats.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

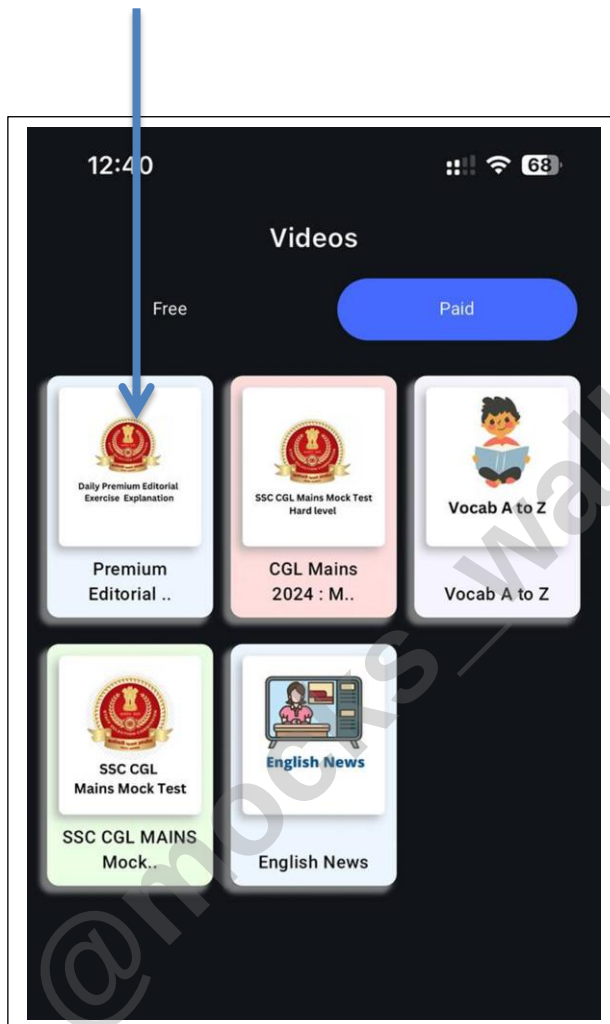
Vocabulary

1. **Septic tank** (noun) – a tank, typically underground, in which sewage is collected and allowed to decompose through bacterial activity before draining by means of a soakaway. गंदे पानी की टंकी
2. **Desludging** (noun) – Cleaning, emptying, purging, draining, sanitation – कीचड़ हटाना
3. **Mechanised** (adjective) – Automated, motorised, computerized, robotic, industrialised – यंत्रीकृत
4. **Hazardous** (adjective) – Dangerous, risky, unsafe, perilous, toxic – खतरनाक
5. **Social audit** (noun) – an evaluation of an organization's working procedures, codes of conduct, and the impact of their operations on social welfare. सामाजिक लेखा परीक्षण
6. **Table** (verb) – Present, submit, propose, introduce, put forward – प्रस्तुत करना
7. **Lie** (verb) – Exist, reside, dwell, be situated, be found – स्थित होना
8. **Deleterious** (adjective) – Harmful, damaging, injurious, detrimental, unsafe – हानिकारक
9. **Payroll** (noun) – Wage list, employee register, salary record, pay sheet, roster – वेतन सूची
10. **Obscure** (verb) – Hide, mask, blur, conceal, cover – अस्पष्ट करना
11. **Liability** (noun) – Responsibility, accountability, obligation, burden, debt – दायित्व
12. **Front** (noun) – Field, area, domain, aspect, zone – क्षेत्र
13. **Lag** (verb) – Delay, fall behind, trail, dawdle, loiter – पिछड़ जाना
14. **Prohibition** (noun) – Ban, restriction, bar, constraint, embargo – निषेध
15. **Scavenger** (noun) – Cleaner, waste collector, refuse worker, sweeper, sanitation worker – कचरा उठाने वाला
16. **Rehabilitation** (noun) – Restoration, reintegration, recovery, resettlement, renewal – पुनर्वास
17. **Nationwide** (adjective) – Across the country, all-India, countrywide, pan-national, extensive – राष्ट्रव्यापी
18. **Bright spot** (noun) – Positive aspect, hope, advantage, uplifting element, silver lining – आशाजनक पहलू
19. **Pilot** (verb) – Test, trial, experiment, initiate, implement – प्रायोगिक रूप से शुरू करना

20. **Will** (noun) – Intention, determination, resolve, desire, drive – इच्छा/संकल्प
21. **Flag** (verb) – Highlight, raise, indicate, bring attention to, signal – चिन्हित करना
22. **Enforcement** (noun) – Implementation, execution, imposition, reinforcement, application – प्रवर्तन
23. **Infrastructure** (noun) – Framework, facilities, foundation, system, base – आधारभूत संरचना
24. **Robotically** (adverb) – Automatically, mechanically, systematically, machine-like, unthinkingly – यांत्रिक रूप से
25. **Capital subsidy** (noun) – a grant provided by a government or other entity to reduce the cost of capital for businesses, typically to encourage investment in specific sectors or regions.
26. **Solicit** (verb) – Request, seek, invite, ask for, call for – अनुरोध करना
27. **Bid** (noun) – Tender, offer, proposal, quotation, submission – बोली
28. **Paper tiger** (noun) – something, such as an enemy or foreign country, that seems very strong and dangerous but is really weak and not harmful. खोखली धमकी/दिखावटी ताकत
29. **In the event of** (phrase) – If happens, in case of, should it occur, upon, when – की स्थिति में
30. **Book** (verb) – Charge, record, arrest, register, file – मामला दर्ज करना
31. **Classify** (verb) – Categorize, label, group, rank, sort – वर्गीकृत करना
32. **Offending** (adjective) – relating to the committing of an illegal act or the breaking of a rule. गैर-कानूनी
33. **Monetary** (adjective) – Financial, fiscal, economic, budgetary, pecuniary – मौद्रिक/वित्तीय
34. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, apply, levy, dictate, command – थोपना
35. **Principal** (adjective) – Main, primary, chief, leading, foremost – मुख्य
36. **Employer** (noun) – Boss, manager, proprietor, recruiter, contractor – नियोक्ता
37. **Rehabilitation** (noun) – (Repeated above – same meaning) – पुनर्वास
38. **Contemptible** (adjective) – Despicable, shameful, vile, disgraceful, abhorrent – घृणास्पद
39. **Occupation** (noun) – Job, profession, employment, vocation, livelihood – पेशा

40. **Sweep** (verb) – Clean, brush, mop, scrub, scour – झाड़ू लगाना suspect without a warrant and begin an investigation immediately. संज्ञेय अपराध
41. **Post-haste** (adjective) – Urgent, immediate, without delay, swift, prompt – शीघ्र
42. **Valid** (adjective) – Legitimate, lawful, acceptable, authorized, certified – वैध
43. **Cognisable offence** (noun) – a serious crime for which a police officer can arrest a
44. **Upscale** (verb) – Expand, upgrade, enhance, enlarge, amplify – उच्च स्तर पर ले जाना
45. **Profiling** (noun) – the activity of collecting important and useful details about someone or something प्रोफाइल बनाना/विवरण बनाना

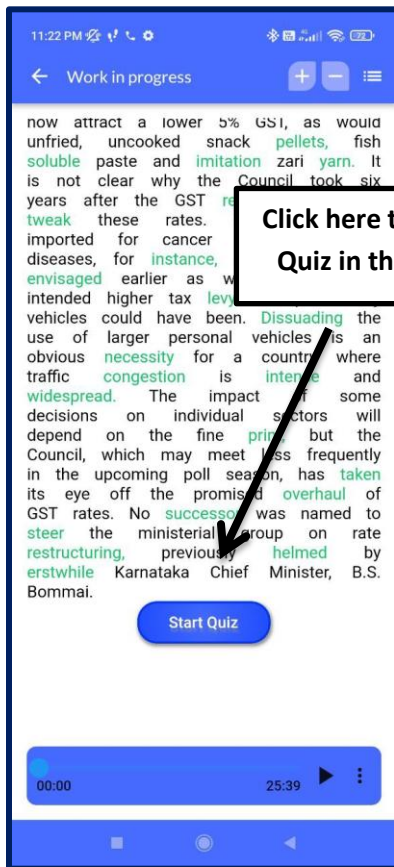
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



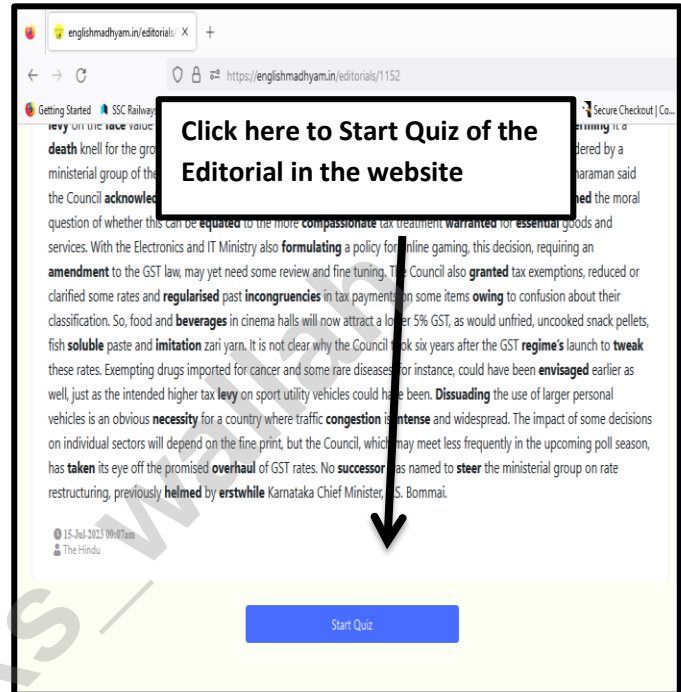
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Hazardous Deaths:** Between 2022 and 2023, 150 people died while cleaning septic tanks, highlighting the dangers of manual scavenging.
2. **Audit Findings:** A social audit of 54 deaths revealed that most workers were either local contract workers or public employees “loaned” to private contractors, blurring accountability.
3. **Legal Framework Ignored:** Despite the 2013 Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers Act and other government initiatives, enforcement remains weak.
4. **Poor Safety Provision:** Out of nearly 58,000 workers, only around 16,791 had been provided with PPE kits, and very few received health cards or training.
5. **NAMASTE Scheme Gaps:** The 2023 NAMASTE scheme has had limited implementation, with only ₹14 crore released — inadequate even for one major city.
6. **State Success Stories:** Odisha has provided workers with mechanised desludging tools and PPEs; Tamil Nadu has introduced robotic cleaners in Chennai.
7. **Technology Potential:** Industry experts affirm that most sewer infrastructure can be robotically cleaned if subsidies and training are improved.
8. **Manual Tenders Persist:** Government contracts still solicit manual cleaning bids, undermining mechanisation efforts.
9. **Enforcement Failures:** Emergency response units are non-functional, and worker deaths are often classified as accidents, shielding top officials from liability.
10. **Judicial Intervention:** The Supreme Court has urged cancellation of unsafe contracts and penalties for principal employers, but local governments have not acted.
11. **Caste Injustice:** Two-thirds of manual scavenging workers are Dalits, yet rehabilitation rarely includes housing or educational support.
12. **Neglected Women Workers:** Women still forced to sweep dry latrines are even more overlooked in policy frameworks.
13. **Mandatory Mechanisation:** Sewer cleaning must be fully mechanised and turned into a licensed, regulated trade with criminal penalties for violations.
14. **Supportive Financing:** Loans to workers to own and operate cleaning machinery should be scaled up and backed by service contracts from municipalities.
15. **Expand Rural Reach:** The central government must bring septic tank cleaning under the Swachh Bharat rural budget and extend the NAMASTE scheme to gram panchayats.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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